

‘I want to reach the Olympics podium as a sprinter’, says Odisha’s PRATIK MAHARANA

The 40th National Junior Athletics Championships has concluded in Bhubaneswar. Over 2000 athletes competed on the track and field of Kalinga Stadium. Several athletes made a mark and smashed long-standing records. Odisha ended its campaign with 7 medals across age categories. But one name stood out in the sea of talent making waves at Kalinga. That belongs to the up-and-coming sprinter, Pratik Maharana the rising star of Odisha.

Born in Odisha’s Bargarh to a businessman father Judhisthir Maharana and a housewife mother Urmila, track and field was not Pratik’s initial choice of sport as a kid. “I always played cricket, loved it as a kid,” says Pratik. But fate clearly had different plans for the young sprinter. A chanced encounter with his coach Siba Mishra during a cricket match changed the trajectory of his life.

“Siba sir saw me playing cricket in Bargarh and asked if I wanted to run. I immediately said yes. That is how my journey in athletics began,” he adds. While his training continued unhindered under the tutelage of his coach, the covid pandemic pushed his sprinting dreams to the back burner. Bugged down by circumstances, Maharana had to take up odd jobs to keep himself and his family afloat during the challenging times. Off the tracks for over two years, his coach rediscovered him on a trip to his hometown in 2022, who then brought him to Rourkela and began training him at the Birsa Munda Athletics Stadium. Pratik has not looked back ever since.

Cut to 13 October 2025, he breached the qualifying mark in 200m sprint event for the World Athletics U20 Championships 2026, which will be held in the USA. Cheers erupted at the stadium as Pratik clocked a timing of 21.24s, his personal best, along with a gold



medal. “The curve is my favourite place on the tracks, feels like a burst of energy rushes through me when I run past it,” smiles the usually shy and reserved lad. On 11 October, Pratik had clinched silver in the mens 100m event with a timing of 10.74s in the same Championship.

While a talent like Pratik is hard to miss, Amiya Mallick, one of the greats of the Indian sprint, has a sharp observation about the youngster from his state, “Pratik’s block start can be better, he has the time and age on his side and can definitely improve in this aspect,” observes the former 100m national record holder, while evaluating his junior’s performance in the nationals. Athletics Federation of India has announced Indian squad for South Asian Senior Athletics Championships, and Pratik will compete for India in the 200m and 4x100m events. His current focus is to better his timing, bring laurels for the country, his state and secure a place in the final Indian Contingent for the World Championships. “I am not running for a job, I want to finish on the Olympics podium one day,” signs off Pratik.